



Social identification effects in product and process development teams

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Abstract

This study integrated theories of group effectiveness with social identity and social categorization theory to develop and test a model of team performance. The sample included 42 product and process development teams employed in three divisions of a Fortune 500 manufacturing firm. Performance data was collected at project midpoint and at project completion through both managers' and team members' assessments. The study found that team social identification was an important predictor of team performance, explaining variance beyond that explained by cohesiveness and external communication. Team social identification was influenced by top management support and recognition, project leader organizational influence, the extent to which members' time was dedicated to the team, and team functional diversity. Implications for scholars and professional managers are discussed. © 1997 Elsevier Science B.V.

Keywords: Projects; Teams; Social identification; Product development

1. Introduction

Today, task forces and project teams are recognized as important mechanisms for the effective management of nonroutine problems in organizations (Gersick, 1988). Project teams allow organizations to reconfigure their internal structures on an 'as needed' basis, mobilizing unique combinations of differentiated knowledge and expertise, and simultaneously providing closer coupling of functional areas (Ancona, 1990). They provide flexibility, increased responsiveness to external conditions, and tighter control of resources through scheduling at the project level (Katz and Allen, 1985).

Arguably, temporary teams are of the greatest benefit to organizations in the context

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